

Hackers reveal how Flock cameras really track cars and people

One hacked camera captured 1.6 million images and could detect people as well as cars.

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Flock license plate reader and camera with solar panel in Pleasant Hill, California on April 16, 2026.

Credit: Getty Images | Smith Collection/Gado

 TEXT SETTINGS

Hackers ripped down a Flock camera above a roadway, made a near-complete copy of the data stored inside it, and shared the files with 404 Media and WIRED, revealing in new detail how exactly Flock Safety's cameras track the movements of both vehicles and people. The hackers say they are also publishing details on how they managed to obtain the software, in the hopes that other people may copy them.

The breach provides an unprecedented look inside a system that Flock has described as protected by on-device encryption. The hackers were able to copy the camera's storage and recover an encryption key stored on the device, which unlocked videos of thousands of vehicle detections. The hackers shared the material with 404 Media and the transparency nonprofit Distributed Denial of Secrets, which shared the data with WIRED. 404 Media and WIRED then analyzed those files as part of a joint investigation.

While much of the automatic license plate reader's most sensitive storage remained encrypted and inaccessible, the joint analysis of the recovered data shows that software running on the device explicitly detects people as well as vehicles, license plates, and bicycles. The camera can produce dozens of images of a single passing vehicle and, according to several weeks of recovered logs, generated more than a million images. Its computer-vision software also sometimes isolated bumper stickers and other graphics, including, in one case, an American flag patch on a motorcyclist's saddlebag.

The act of removing the camera and dumping its software shows that some people are not content with just destroying or removing the cameras. Across the country, multiple people have been arrested for allegedly tampering with or otherwise sabotaging Flock's cameras. In response, some towns have announced that they are going to stop using Flock's cameras altogether, and in one case, a police department even made a fake, 3D-printed Flock camera case in order to bait potential vandals.

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"Why just destroy them when we can reverse engineer them and find the secrets of those spying on us?" one of the hackers, from a collective calling itself stegan0gram, said in an interview. "We liberated hardware in the field, disarmed them, and proceeded with reverse engineering of the cameras and associated solar equipment."

Flock's cameras photograph passing vehicles and send the images and other data to the company's servers. There, Flock's system presumably reads the license plate and can identify characteristics, such as the vehicle's color, make, and model. Flock then makes these time-stamped records searchable by whichever local agency owns or has access to the cameras. But in many cases, Flock's system also allows other police departments from all over the country to search those cameras as part of the company's national network. In Alpharetta, Georgia, for example, WIRED found that records from the city's Flock cameras were accessible to more than 2,000 agencies,

including police departments, colleges, airports, and for the federal General Services Administration.

This national network has been a selling point for Media revealed that local cops were performing local Immigration and Customs Enforcement, including authorities or transferring license plate data out of Texas searched Flock cameras nationwide for a week. Stories, among others, triggered a national conversation about cameras, or automatic license plate readers more

And in the case of steganogram, the answer is clear.

The hackers said they were able to access the And partitions—sections of its hard drive, essentially. / said, including one called “vendor” and another called key that unlocked another part, which contained information the camera took.

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In early 2025, security researcher Jon “GainSec” Gainey reader and documented flaws that could be used to exploit his findings, the company acknowledged the findings the flaws required physical access to the device and the camera “would still not be able to gain access to the data” only briefly after being transmitted to the cloud.

404 Media and WIRED analyzed the camera’s code, used in midrange smartphones, and it runs about detecting motion and taking pictures to classify images, updates.

According to the code, when something moves into the A typical passing vehicle generated about 28 images. The camera uses different exposures to capture both the front and the images, selects and crops useful frames, and sends

cellular network. The camera itself does not appear to have a model, and color. That appears to happen on Flock cameras.

According to our analysis, the camera's logs record only in specific periods. During those windows, the device photographs about 1.6 million images. On a typical day, it logs about 1.6 million images. Those figures would vary considerably depending on how much traffic passes in front of it. The camera was almost always on, and older logs had been overwritten or were no longer available.

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The software running on the camera explicitly detected faces, but it overlooked in discussions around Flock cameras. It doesn't appear in the image and how confident it is in the detection.

To test what the software could actually see, WIRED ran tests and ran them against test images and footage recorded by the camera. It detected people, including a selfie of a reporter. We also found video clips stored on the camera. The clips were mostly of motorcycles recorded at 1,024 by 768 pixels without audio. The camera also takes still images the resolution of the video clips. The camera also takes still images of the clips, all of them riding motorcycles. The small camera was mounted above a roadway, pointed down at passing traffic.

The tests also showed how broadly the camera's lens sees. In some cases it mistook bumper stickers, dealerships, and cropped them out as if they were plates. In one case, it cropped an American flag patch on the rider's saddlebag.

Flock insists its cameras do not perform face recognition. It says of any face-recognition capabilities in the camera's software are part of the Android operating system. Those capabilities are not used.

In August, WIRED obtained frontend code for Flock cameras, previously known as Nightshift, and reconstructed how Flock can use the records generated by its camera.

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identify drivers and surface vehicles that repeated patterns of movement. The data provides a view c

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A Flock spokesperson said in a statement: “The ur camera is illegal.” When asked specifically about t company added, “Flock takes security seriously a Policy for security researchers to report potential report through that process, and based on the lim enough detail to assess the claims being made. If vulnerabilities, we encourage them to submit thei reporting process so our security team can review

One of the hackers said, “Being investigated is a le avoid. I’m sure our actions have attracted some at a low profile.”

Noel Pichardo, a former Pawtucket, Rhode Island, Flock after challenging his department’s use of the frustration but worries that sabotaging devices co think that type of vigilantism will only crystallize t this tool is necessary,” Pichardo says. “The longer their constituents who are against this type of sur

The camera’s logs also show the camera strugglin 27,000 “no space left on device” errors while tryin of thousands of related errors, crashes, and reboo code checked that the camera was still running ar More than 12,000 of those messages appear in the

When the camera did restart, another service left a requested! ¡Adiós, Amigos!”

This story originally appeared on wired.com.

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